

How common is it?

Last revised in March 2025

- **Diabetes is one of the most common chronic diseases in the UK, and its prevalence is increasing** [NICE, 2020a ([/topics/diabetes-type-2/references/](#))].
 - In 2018–2019 there were 3,919,505 people diagnosed with diabetes [Diabetes UK, 2019b ([/topics/diabetes-type-2/references/](#))].
 - About 90% of adults currently diagnosed have type 2 diabetes [Diabetes UK, 2019a ([/topics/diabetes-type-2/references/](#))].
 - About one million people with type 2 diabetes are currently undiagnosed [Diabetes UK, 2019a ([/topics/diabetes-type-2/references/](#))].
 - A primary care cohort study analysis of the General Practice Research Database of 1.3 million patients in England and Wales estimated [Ryan, 2005 ([/topics/diabetes-type-2/references/](#))]:
 - The rate of diagnosis of new cases of diabetes (type not specified) was 17.5 per 10,000 person-years in 1994 and 22.1 per 10,000 person-years in 1998, representing an increase in new cases of 26% over the study period.
 - The National Institute for Health and Care Excellence (NICE) estimates that by 2025, more than 5 million people in the UK will be diagnosed with diabetes [NICE, 2020a ([/topics/diabetes-type-2/references/](#))].
- **Type 2 diabetes can occur in all age groups and is increasingly being diagnosed in children** [NICE, 2020a ([/topics/diabetes-type-2/references/](#))].
 - About 36,000 children and young people under the age of 19 years have diabetes, of which about 10% have type 2 diabetes (or other rarer types of diabetes) [Diabetes UK, 2019a ([/topics/diabetes-type-2/references/](#))].
 - A UK and Republic of Ireland prospective monthly surveillance study reported a total of 106 new cases of type 2 diabetes diagnosed in children and young people aged less than 17 years between 1st April 2015 and 30th April 2016, equating to a UK incidence of 0.72 per 100,000 children and young people per year [Candler, 2018b ([/topics/diabetes-type-2/references/](#))].
 - Children from Asian and Black and Afro-Caribbean ethnic groups had a significantly higher incidence than white children, as did girls compared with boys.
 - There was a trend in increased incidence from 2005 to 2015.
 - It concludes that type 2 diabetes remains much less common than type 1 diabetes in childhood in the UK, but the number of cases diagnosed is rising.
- **The trends in reported global incidence of type 2 diabetes vary in the literature depending on the country, age group, and ethnicity of the population studied.**
 - A Global Burden of Disease Study analysis found [Liu, 2020 ([/topics/diabetes-type-2/references/](#))]:
 - The global age-standardized incidence rate of type 2 diabetes significantly increased from 228 per 100,000 people in 1990 to 279 per 100,000 people in 2017, with an estimated annual percentage change of 0.89.
 - A systematic review of 42 global population-based studies of diabetes incidence trends found the incidence of total or type 2 diabetes in the populations studied [Magliano, 2019 ([/topics/diabetes-type-2/references/](#))]:
 - Increased in 66%, stabilized in 32%, and decreased in 2% from 1990 to 2005.

- Increased in 33%, stabilized in 30%, and decreased in 36% from 2006 to 2014.
- Note: the authors noted that only 4% of studies were from low- and middle-income countries, so available data from these populations were limited and the results may not fully reflect incidence patterns in these populations.

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